

Matthew on Money

By

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MATTHEW ON MONEY

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The occupational training of Matthew is plainly perceptible in the gospel he has written. When he left the receipt of custom to become a follower of Christ and then an apostle and even a gospel historian he carried with him his financial bent and ability. He always speaks of money with the accuracy and discrimination of a man who is accustomed to its possession and use.

Ideal Givers

Matthew alone of the four gospel writers mentions the visit of the Wise Men. They came a great distance in search of him who was born King of the Jews. They knew him on sight, fell down and worshiped him, and opened their treasures and offered unto him gifts, gold and frankincense and myrrh. They give while they are in his presence and while they are in the spirit of worship.

Their purpose was threefold, to see the King, to worship him and to offer gifts to him. The sight of the Christ, infant as he was, called forth the whole program. There was no other appeal. Their giving was a part of their confession of faith. This is the King whom they came to accept and honor. They are not mistaken nor in doubt. They behold and worship and give.

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When men open their hearts they also open their treasures. “No man becomes honest” says Frederick W. Robertson, “till he gets face to face with God.” Delusion vanishes then and there and opportunity appears. Then men prize their privilege. Come to Christ, worship him and go without giving? When men come into the presence of Christ as did the Wise Men they fail not nor falter but act in a way that meets expectations.

A Would-be Giver

In his fourth chapter Matthew tells how Satan proposed to give the world to Christ, a great offer and fitting in a sense but one our Lord could not accept on the terms stated or from this would-be giver. How could he receive a gift from Satan without being subordinated to him? How can a Christian do this same thing without change of character and loss of life?

Were Christ to receive the world as a gift from Satan he would still need to save it from sin if a redeemed world is what he wants. Satan cannot give what he does not possess. But whatever his right of ownership his offer 5 was not intended to aid our Lord but to tempt him to betray His trust.

Matthew thinks Satan proposed to give only as a last resort and after other means had failed. Giving appears to be the hardest thing for him to do or he may regard it as the climax of his appeal. He was in the presence of Christ but he proposes to give his own gift in his own way to further his own ends. Satan remains Satan in the presence of Christ, unchanged and unchangeable.

Satan requests Christ to fall down and worship him while Christ replies, “Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God.” Satan has no disposition to follow the example of the Wise Men or to adopt their order of procedure. He asks our Lord to accept his gift and then worship him in acknowledgement of his supremacy. He offers temporal things for spiritual service, earthly greatness for divine recognition.

Unlike the Wise Men Satan is unlike God also, who sends his rain upon the just and the unjust. God’s giving springs from his love, is measured by it

and is the expression of it. God so loved the world that He gave His Son. His giving is a real bestowment and not a deceptive deal. He gives according to his nature and men receive according to their ability.

Well we know that God can give
Knowledge of the way to live.
Give he will and give he must
Unto all who in him trust,
Right thru things that lie between
God can give while yet unseen.

6

But God gives ministry instead of mastery. “It is the most fantastic of all dreams,” says Newman Hall, “that a man can cut his being into two portions, call one of them religious and the other mundane, and administer them on directly opposite principles.” As Christ was not deluded, divided and directed by Satan neither can Christians be if they are to remain Christians.

Inside Information

The references to money which appear in the sermon on the mount as reported by Matthew offer inside information on the subject.

Jesus came to fulfil the law, not to destroy it, not to lower religion. Our religion must have expression in our life for only life at its best can satisfy us. Prof. Stalker tells us that “The task of religious teachers is to get people to see things as they are,” and we may add, as they ought to be.

Jesus requires more than external compliance with the law or formal righteousness and hence his followers must be better than Pharisees. They must act from right motives when they pray and give alms and be confidential with the Father who seeth in secret. The Pharisee’s reward, to be seen of men, seems utterly insignificant as compared with that of the Christian, “Thy Father who seeth in secret shall reward thee.” “Thy Father” and not “our Father,” as elsewhere: for here the transaction is confidential and personal; “Reward thee” as an individual who merits his consideration.

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The approval of our Father in heaven is worth while as well as good standing in our community. Both are possible and Dr. Deems emphasizes the value of both when he says: “One good man given to a town is better than the gift of a park or a library and is worth more to a town than a hundred of the most learned men who are not good.”

“Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth,” says Jesus to His disciples and his precept is illustrated by His example. Your life must not be limited by money. Earthly treasures may be stolen or destroyed. Money-making may hinder laying up treasures in heaven, “For where thy treasure is, there will thy heart be also.”

Christians are essentially heavenly in character and life and so Paul says, “Our citizenship is in heaven.” They are industrious, economical, thrifty and enterprising but their life centers in the spiritual and the wealth 8 they possess is owned and used, not for themselves alone, but for their families and neighbors, their friends and even their enemies, the Church and nation.

Jesus declares that men must have the light of God and singleness of eye in order to see. Men must learn to see as God sees. No man can serve two masters, God and Mammon, only two being mentioned for there are no more. God sees men as they are and is never in doubt while men get things mixed up and try to do opposites. They think of food and raiment when they ought to think of God’s kingdom and His righteousness. They ought to put first things first in order to get other things in their proper place.

Of course there are people who dislike those who see as God sees and do as Christ directs but good people are not on this account to give away holy things and cast aside the pearls they possess. Good people have a right to be good even if “the dogs” and “the swine” have no appreciation of the higher things of life. The continued possession of “pearls” and “that which is holy” has the approval of Jesus.

He even commands his followers to ask of God who knows what is best for them and who is described as “your Father” when it comes to giving to 9 them. He wishes to be asked for what they want and gives “good things” in answer to their requests. This is information every child of God

should have because it comes from the lips of Jesus and is inside information as regards God's will as set forth in his word and also with reference to our own personal experience.

Money outclassed

When Jesus sent forth the twelve as described in the tenth chapter they were to proclaim the kingdom of heaven, to heal the sick, to raise the dead, to cleanse the lepers and cast out demons, a remarkable program, which they were to carry out with no gold or silver or brass in their purses. They were to preach without pay, serve without salary, minister without money. They were to outclass money, the medium of exchange, which bears the stamp of some established government. They were to take rank among men by doing benevolent work under divine direction and with divine assistance.

They were instructed to rely upon the people for the supply of their ordinary needs. No one was permitted to burden himself with two coats and thus belie his message and his Master. Their moral earnestness was to be maintained under all circumstances and in case any refused to receive them or hear their words they were to shake off the dust of their feet for a testimony against them. 10

“If God's truth is to succeed,” says Dr. Gregg, “it must incarnate itself: if God's cause is to win a victory it must embody itself in a person.” Men must be the truth in order to preach the truth in its purity and power. Ministers must be sent by Christ, receive authority from him, follow his program, outclass money and take rank among men as his representatives.

A Teacher Taught

Peter's mistake with reference to payment of the temple tax which is recorded in the seventeenth of Matthew was not the only mistake Peter made. There were others and all were corrected, the correction in this case being memorable if not also unforgettable.

Peter promised payment without consulting Jesus. He thought he knew what Jesus would do in the case and to confess ignorance would lower him in the estimation of those who received the tax. But Peter had failed to consider the fact that as the Son in the house of his Father Jesus was free. Jesus points out Peter's error as a friend who will not allow his mistake to be incorporated in his thought and life only to vitiate both. 11

Jesus takes account also of those who received the tax for they were not prepared to receive his explanation. His miraculous power is called into service to relieve the situation. And why not? Is not his Sonship called in question? He directs Peter where and how to get the required shekel. For a little while Peter returns to his former occupation but his skill as a fisherman is supplemented by the superior knowledge and power of Christ and so when he makes payment it is "for me and thee" because Peter's position is not the same as that of the Master.

Our Lord is careful where men are inclined to be careless. Trifles may make the sum of life but life is no trifle. "You may be too superb to pay attention to the small debt due your neighbor," says Dr. Deems, "but God is so great that he can pay attention to the least of things." Matthew's four verses concerning a matter of thirty-three cents have their place and their use in scripture. We soon lose sight of the half shekel and center our thoughts upon Christ, who corrects Peter so faithfully, who respects the feelings of those who receive the tax and who even takes account of us at this distance by giving us this minute view of himself. Little things like this reveal the greatness of our Lord and just such touches confirm Prof. Stalker's statement that "the pagan world not only never produced one holy man but never drew the picture of one." 12

God in the Case

In the nineteenth chapter we find these words from the lips of Jesus: "It is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven. It is easier for a camel to go through a needle's eye, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God." He is stating a thing that is impossible and the disciples ask in amazement, "Who then can be saved?" Their question calls forth His

answer, “With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.” Men can be reconstituted but this requires divine assistance. As Canon Westcot has said, “Jesus established fresh foundations for society and a fresh standard of individual worth.”

Is it still hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven? As hard as ever and absolutely impossible as long as he makes riches his object in life, as long as he compromises with evil for a consideration, as long as he ruins competitors in business in order to create a monopoly. But does the Church know what Jesus meant to teach? Yes, if it knows itself and its duty, which is “to show to the world its chief concern is morality, not money; principles, not profits; the faith of the crucified Christ, not the favors of men who have accumulated fortunes without righteousness.” 13

Six words contain the solution of the whole problem, “With God all things are possible.” God can so completely transform a rich man that he can forget he is rich. He can think of himself as a man and as a servant of God. He can see himself as a sinner before God and also as saved by grace thru faith in Jesus Christ. He enters the kingdom not as rich but as believing. In the Simple Life we read: “If there are people at once rich and content, be assured that they are content because they know how to be, not because they are rich.”

God can trust saved men with money, to possess it, to invest it and to use it in the interest of His kingdom. But he cannot permit men who worship wealth to enter His kingdom. This is impossible. An unchanged nature cannot enter the kingdom of God and could not find happiness there because it is out of harmony with the laws and the life of the kingdom.

Use or Misuse

Two verses of chapter twenty-one suffice to record the manner in which Jesus treated traders in the temple. They were out of place. With no appreciation of the temple as a place of worship they naturally used it for their own ends and Jesus as naturally came in conflict with these mercenary men. After he cast them out he told them what the temple is for, 14

“My house shall be called a house of prayer: but ye make it a den of robbers.” Such perversion is not permitted and their misused opportunity is suddenly forfeited.

Men who misuse God’s house invite their own overthrow. They are driven out by the very One who invites sincere souls to enter. Their punishment fits their sin. They have no place in the house of God, no part in his salvation, no share in his service.

The use and misuse of opportunity are set forth in comparison and in contrast in chapter twenty-five. Two of the servants in the parable of the talents proved worthy of their trust while one failed to appreciate his opportunity. Did the unequal division anger the man who received the one talent? The opportunity of the three servants is essentially the same, which appears plainly when their lord reckons with them. In identical terms he commends the two who so used their talents as to increase their holdings. How could he commend the servant who brought back his lord’s money without increase and in addition lodged a complaint against him? 15

“The servant with the one talent considered himself a brilliant example of a harmless man,” says Dr. Deems. His talent is returned unused and without loss or increase. He is condemned on two counts, inactivity and insincerity. If he really thought his master was exceedingly strict why did he not act accordingly? His conduct belied his profession.

Our thoughts are usually called to the man with the one talent but the man with the two and the man with the five deserve our attention quite as much. The men with the most do the best. They are trustworthy. They are faithful servants and are left in possession of what they were given and what they gained. The man who had most of all received the unused one talent as an additional trust and as a mark of his lord’s complete confidence.

Equality of possessions is not the purpose of God toward men but equal opportunity to use well what they have. Talents are a test of character. A servant of God can safely become a custodian of wealth. He must enter into partnership with God before he can expect to hear him say, “Well done, good and faithful servant: enter into the joy of thy Lord.”

Devotion or Desertion

The anointing of Jesus in Bethany in the house of Simon the leper is told in eight verses of the twenty-sixth chapter while the next three verses give an account of Judas in the act of selling the Master. In the first account we have devotion and in the second desertion. Extremes have done what they often do and here we behold them each confronting the other.

A woman poured precious ointment on the head of Jesus as he sat at meat. Her devotion transcended all ordinary bounds being justified by His transcendent ministry. Had He not taught her lessons which no other teacher ever unfolded? Had he not befriended her when Lazarus lay in the tomb? Her ministry, so sincere and so timely, fills a place in his life and work and hence her deed of devotion is accepted with approval and even woven into the gospel record as a memorial of her.

Do we wonder why the disciples become critics, if not opposers, and ask with indignation, "To what purpose is this waste?" They saw no reason for it, no excuse. Unaware of the near approach of Christ's death and burial they were quite well informed as to the cash value of the ointment. They were living on a business basis and thinking of an empty treasury and the needs of the poor. But Jesus explained to them just why they made complaint and why this woman anointed him. 17

It is apparent that the disciples are not yet free from commercialism or they would know that devotion to Christ always helps and never hinders ministering to the poor. They are devoted to Jesus and whether they know it or not they are concerned about His approaching death and His victory over sin. But this woman surpassed them in devotion and in anticipating that victory. Of course there came a time when no ointment was too precious to measure the interest or express the devotion of these same disciples.

Right after Mary's act of devotion Matthew places Judas' deed of defection. Life is logical in its course and outcome. "Whatsoever a man soweth that shall he also reap." Faith in Christ is not the same as doubt and denial, at the beginning, in its process, or at the end. The two are radically different

and this difference must appear at the end if nowhere else. Extremes may meet but they are still extremes.

The devotion that anointed Jesus for his burial may have incited Judas to betray him. He is indignant and must act and the nature of his act was determined by his own character. “Then one of the twelve, who was 18 called Judas Iscariot, went unto the chief priests, and said, ‘What are ye willing to give me, and I will deliver him unto you?’ And they weighed unto him thirty pieces of silver.”

Judas assumed the right to sell Jesus as Satan assumed the right to bestow the world as a gift. The chief priests gladly act on the assumption of Judas and Jesus was sold by the latter and purchased by the former as though he were a slave. The bargain is satisfactory to buyer and seller, the purchase price is paid and accepted and the transaction is complete! If this contract takes any account of the innocence of Jesus, his wonderful teaching and his miraculous ministry it is as so many counts against him.

Men always throw the cloak of charity over their shoulders when they propose to do an uncharitable thing. They will build the tombs of the prophets who are dead while they arrange to betray God’s living leaders. They take care of their reputation but neglect their character. They do popular things which in no way commit them to the cause of Christ. But men cannot remain indifferent to Christ. He literally compels decision, and men must choose, their choice lying between sale and service, the defection of Judas and the devotion of Mary. There is no resting place between 19 the two. The Christ leaves no room for doubt and indecision for just as sure as he did he would not be the Christ.

Recapitulation

Matthew’s references to money are found here and there, not random remarks or unrelated statements, but parts of the truth, which fit together in an “orderly procession of thought.” They embody an ideal, reveal motives, describe character and show us the evil use of money lest we be deceived and misled.

The Wise Men gave in recognition of Christ as the promised King while Satan proposed to give in order to dethrone Him.

Christ came to fulfil the law, to raise religion to its proper level. According to Him, motives count, and in prayer and alms-giving point unerringly to the source of reward.

Our earth-life is not to be earth-bound. Men are called upon to lay up treasures in heaven wisely anticipating their appearance there.

Christ gives authority to men whom he sends forth as his representatives. They are not to rely on cash or clothes but to trust God for the truth they teach and power to sustain them, and the people for food and shelter.

Peter's mistake about the tax arose from inadequate knowledge of Christ after years of instruction and at the close of the earthly life of Jesus. Riches are an obstruction to **rich** men but not to **saved** men. 20

A right idea of God and a right relation to God prepare men for a right use of money and any talent they possess.

The woman who anointed Jesus manifested her devotion and the man who betrayed Him gave vent to his disappointment and proclaimed his disaffection.

Transcriber's Notes

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